

**FIN 700 Research Methods (69658) - Fall 2026**  
**W.P. Carey School of Business**  
**Arizona State University**

## **Instructor**

Mingyang Zhang [mzhan235@asu.edu](mailto:mzhan235@asu.edu)

Tingquan Pan [tpan18@asu.edu](mailto:tpan18@asu.edu)

## **Course Description**

Fin 700 is a boot camp course on research methods in Finance. The course meets on Saturdays during Fall semester and is required for all new FIN PhD students. Class is dynamically dated.

## **Learning Goals**

The W.P. Carey School of Business has established the following learning goals for its graduate students:

1. Critical Thinking
2. Communication
3. Discipline Specific Knowledge
4. Research Methods

## **Course Learning Outcomes**

On completion of this course, students will be able to:

1. Understand basic math concepts and finance application in linear algebra, probability theory, statistics.
2. Understand basic empirical research methods and datasets.

## **Required Textbook and Other Materials**

No textbook is required. Lecture notes will be distributed.

No software is required. However, we highly recommend selecting **at most one** software or coding language (e.g. Python, STATA, SAS, MATLAB, Julia, etc.) Switching between coding languages is not recommended.

AI is highly important in research. You are very welcome to work with AI especially agents such as Codex, Claude code, etc.

### **Schedule of Class: (subject to reasonable change)**

- **Aug 1** Welcome, basics, linear algebra
- **Aug 8** linear algebra
- **Aug 15** probability theory
- **Aug 22** Statistics and Machine Learning
- **Sep 29** Empirical Method Overview
- **Sep 5** Difference in Difference
- **Sep 12** Difference in Difference
- **Sep 19** Regression discontinuity

### **Absence Policies**

This is a PhD level course, we expect you to attend all eight classes. If for any reasons you cannot attend, please let me know beforehand and we will try to accommodate your schedule.

### **Academic Integrity and Ethical Behavior**

The W. P. Carey School takes academic integrity very seriously. A student who engages in academic misconduct as outlined in ASU's academic integrity policy (<http://provost.asu.edu/academicintegrity>) while attending a graduate program will receive strict penalties.

Those penalties ordinarily will range from a letter reduction in final course grade to expulsion from the program and School of Business. The penalty will be decided by the course faculty member and the Assistant Dean of Academic Affairs. All allegations of academic misconduct must be reported to program administrators. Any subsequent act of academic misconduct, regardless of severity, will result in dismissal from the program and the School of Business.

Additional information on ASU's academic integrity policy may be found at :

<http://provost.asu.edu/academicintegrity>

### **Honor Code and Professionalism Policy**

<https://gradstudents.wpcarey.asu.edu/student-resources/professionalism-policy>

## **Prohibition Against Discrimination, Harassment, and Retaliation**

Title IX is a federal law that provides that no person be excluded on the basis of sex from participation in, be denied benefits of, or be subjected to discrimination under any education program or activity. Both Title IX and university policy make clear that sexual violence and harassment based on sex is prohibited. An individual who believes they have been subjected to sexual violence or harassed on the basis of sex can seek support, including counseling and academic support, from the university. If you or someone you know has been harassed on the basis of sex or sexually assaulted, you can find information and resources at <https://sexualviolenceprevention.asu.edu/faqs>.

As a mandated reporter, I am obligated to report any information I become aware of regarding alleged acts of sexual discrimination, including sexual violence and dating violence. ASU Counseling Services, <https://eoss.asu.edu/counseling> is available if you wish to discuss any concerns confidentially and privately.

## **Instructor Absence Policy**

Note the policy on how long students should wait for an absent instructor, ACD 304-10:

“How Long Students Should Wait for an Absent Instructor: In the event the instructor fails to indicate a time obligation, the time obligation will be 15 minutes for class sessions lasting 90 minutes or less, and 30 minutes for class sessions lasting more than 90 minutes. Students may be directed to wait longer by someone from the academic unit if they know the instructor will arrive shortly.”

## **Religious Accommodations**

If you require a specific religious accommodation please let me know by August 12 (2<sup>nd</sup> week of class).

Accommodations will be made for students with religious holidays. Below is the calendar of official religious holidays. Each holiday noted with two asterisks denotes an observance for which work is not allowed. For these holidays, students will not be penalized in any way for missing class or assignment. This means that this will not count as an absence in class and they will be granted a makeup assignment or exam, etc. <https://eoss.asu.edu/cora/holidays>

All requests for accommodation must be submitted by the end of the second week of class.

## **University-Sanctioned Activities**

Accommodations will be made for students who miss class related to university-sanctioned activities according to ACD 304-02.

If you are participating in a university-sanctioned activity, please let your instructor know as early in the course as possible so that accommodations can be made.

## **Threatening Behavior Policy**

The university takes threatening behavior very seriously and these situations will be handled in accordance with the *Student Services Manual*, SSM 104-02: <http://www.asu.edu/aad/manuals/ssm/ssm104-02.html>.

## **Student Accessibility and Inclusive Learning Services (SAILS)**

If you need an accommodation for a disability, you must register with Student Accessibility and Inclusive Learning Services (formerly called the DRC). <https://eoss.asu.edu/accessibility>

In alignment with ASU's Charter to be "measured not by whom it excludes, but by whom it includes and how they succeed," the new title (announced in August 2020) represents the office's mission of ensuring that every program, service, event and experience at the university is fully accessible and inclusive to all students, not just those who identify as having a disability.

## **Copyright Material**

Students "must refrain from uploading to any course shell, discussion board, or website used by the course instructor or other course forum, material that is not the student's original work, unless the students first comply with all applicable copyright laws; faculty members reserve the right to delete materials on the grounds of suspected copyright infringement."